

Design controls, yes, but a straitjacket, no

Design controls are an idea whose time has come in America — it came long ago in Europe — and a conference here a couple of weeks ago, sponsored by the Society for the Preservation of New England Antiquities, raised some gut questions about where they're headed.

Design controls, it should be noted, are the rules society makes — if it bothers to make any — about what people can and can't do to the built environment.

They can be tight, as in the Beacon Hill historic district, where you can barely change flowers in your window box, without a permit, or loose, such as the rules most places have against, say, building a factory on a residential street.

When design controls are silly, you get Lexington's papier-mache Colonial

ARCHITECTURE/ROBERT CAMPBELL

supermarkets, or Nantucket's cookie-cut copies of obsolete house types. When they're good, you get a Historic Savannah or Society Hill, where sensitive, explicit rules permit any style but govern the important visual qualities — height, scale, texture, materials, proportion of openings, setback and the rest.

Design controls have traditionally been regarded as being about as American as Mom's blood pudding, as welcome as mange. Even today there are towns like Houston that brag they have none. But increasingly people feel that the old frontier virtue of letting everyone do his thing and calling it Progress has led — especially in the fifty-year period between the arrival of the

car and the departure of urban renewal — to an American landscape and townscape that are perhaps the most disjointed in human history.

SPNEA's conference tackled this vast and ticklish subject with verve. Two panelists especially — James Marson Fitch of Columbia and Denise Scott Brown of the firm of Venturi and Rauch, Philadelphia architects—took opposite sides of the issue with so much intelligence they could have been teaching a course in Humanities I: The Individual and Society.

Fitch was for Society. Brown was for the Individual.

Fitch, who talked first, said the world has changed

too fast and that tearing down neighborhoods and rebuilding them new makes people psychologically uncomfortable. He cited a Polish friend's story that at the end of World War II when Warsaw was rubble, what created the most stress was not starvation or disease, but the absence of familiar things in the environment. You couldn't even say the Polish equivalent of "Meet me at Fourth and Elm" because the streets had disappeared. In rebuilding, the Poles chose not to innovate but reconstruct Warsaw almost stone by stone.

Fitch now heads the program in historic preservation at Columbia, but says he started life as a believer in change. "I would have been perfectly happy to let Le Corbusier tear down the old center of Paris and replace it with skyscrapers," he says. "I've come 180 degrees because I've seen the result of that approach." He quotes Lewis Mumford: "We are the first generation to have the misfortune to see all the things we fought for come true."

So, for Fitch, the problem is setting up strong design controls to assure that change will be slow enough.

For Denise Scott Brown, on the other hand, design controls are society's way of

stifling creativity. She cites two horror stories from her firm's experience. One was the ambush of a Venturi and Rauch project by the notorious Capitol Fine Arts Commission, headed by once avant-garde but now reactionary Gordon Bunshaft, the designer of the terrifying new Hirschhorn Museum, also in Washington. The other story was of Nantucket, where two modest Venturi houses barely made it past a prettifying review board.

Brown thinks design review boards attract people who like power, or as she puts it, "thugs and scoundrels." It's an immemorial plaint of artists. Brown says she wouldn't mind so much if controls could be written into laws so specific as to leave no room for personal interpretation.

It all made a fascinating debate. And, as design review mushrooms, a timely one.

You need only think of Park Plaza, where a citizens' group turned the design completely around, or the Kennedy Library, where informal review processes killed the building. Or even more strikingly, consider that in Massachusetts in 1968 there were 20 historic districts where today there are 255; each with a commission empowered to review the design of new buildings

or alterations in the district. Sign ordinances, anti-fast food statutes and environmental impact statements are all facets of the emerging reality of design controls.

When design controls are as whimsical as Denise Scott Brown says, they're simple terrorism. We must become explicit about what

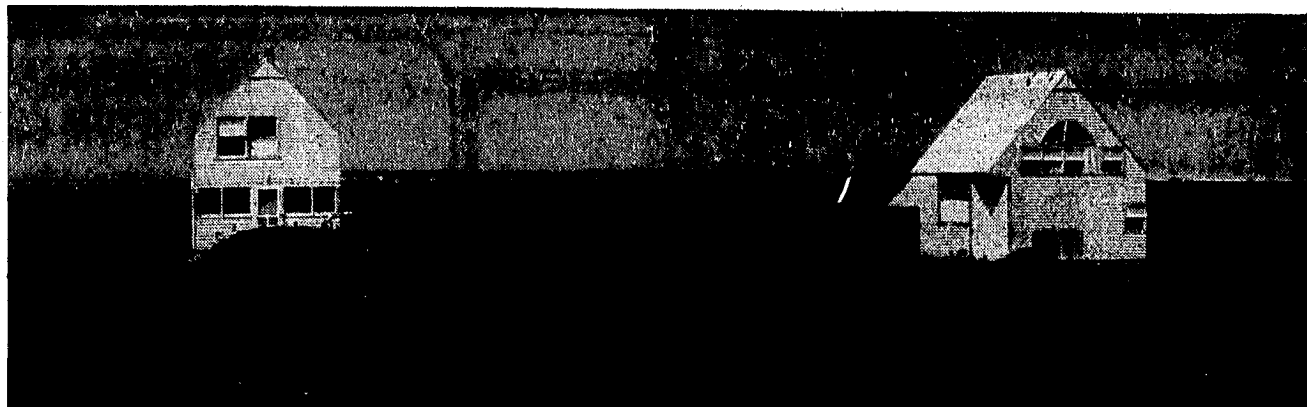
we value in our environment. If we are, controls needn't inhibit anyone's creativity.

In this connection you can't help recalling all the artists through history who have said they needed restrictions in order to create. Robert Frost said writing free verse was like playing tennis without a net. Some

other poet — John Dryden?—said the hateful tyranny of rhyme had hurt him into most of his best lines.

And Stravinsky, whom Fitch quoted, said that in art, when everything is possible, then nothing is possible.

Maybe in this country that's been part of our problem.



Questionable example of design control is Nantucket, where rigid requirement that every new house copy historic types creates monotony. These cottages by Venturi and Rauch, built before present rules, are unhistoric yet fit well in landscape. (Venturi and Rauch photo)



Successful design controls in Society Hill historic district of Philadelphia, allow architect of modern house stylistic freedom while ensuring that his building fits in height, scale, materials, size of openings, setback from sidewalk and other visual features.